

indulgence to their cart, and a whopping 89 percent would add a sale item that looks like a bargain.

The key word, in case you missed it, is *looks*. Consumers across the board love a good deal. But sometimes, what looks like a good deal, really isn't one. How is the average shopper supposed to know the difference? That was what concerned Vance Packard in the 1950s and continues to plague the modern consumer today.

Sometimes maturity and experience is the best teacher of all. As a mother of young children in the 1980s, one of my favorite sales gimmicks was the “blue light special” at our local Kmart. It was created in the 1960s as a way for store managers to draw shoppers’ attention to slow-moving merchandise that was sold at a special discount for a very limited time. There was usually a ten-minute time frame in which the customer had to select their purchases and get them relabeled with the discount before the light was moved to a different section of the store.

I'd be shopping with our two young children when I'd see the blue light flashing. I can vividly remember how I felt as I rushed to the area of the store where the light flashed—the heady rush of adrenaline, the sweaty palms, and quickened heartbeat. It was an effective promotional tool, as I almost always found something when I frantically perused the sale rack or shelf. It was only later, at home, I might pull my purchases out of the shopping bag, perplexed as to what had possessed me to buy four shirts that didn't yet fit either of my children, and when I looked more closely, weren't even a style I cared for. I almost always experienced buyer's remorse after my trips to Kmart. I was the hapless victim of a popular combination of